

The Trust Architecture

What official sources say about how AI search systems choose, and trust, the content they cite

By Aaqib Osman

Every statistic is attributed to a source listed on the final page. Sources reviewed October 2026.

Discovery is shifting. Fast, but from a small base.

1.13B

AI-platform referrals to the world's top 1,000 websites in June 2025, up 357% on June 2024 [1][2].

191B

Google Search referrals to the same sites in the same month [1][2].

456.5K

AI referrals to Kayak, the top travel site in the data. Airbnb had 295.1K and Booking.com 293.7K [1].

AI is still small next to Google, and ChatGPT accounts for over 80% of these referrals on average [1][2]. Pew research reported by TechCrunch found users clicked a result link 8% of the time when an AI summary appeared, against 15% when none did [2].

June 2025 is the most recent dataset I could verify from the primary report. Treat the numbers as a snapshot, not today's figure.

Pages are judged in pieces.

Google says its AI Overviews and AI Mode use retrieval-augmented generation (RAG): relevant pages are retrieved from the Search index to ground the answer. They also use “query fan-out”, running several related searches at once [5].

Microsoft describes assistants like Copilot breaking content into smaller parts, evaluating each for authority and relevance, then assembling an answer, often from several sources [3].

WHAT FOLLOWS (AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS)

If answers are built from retrieved pieces, then each section of a page has to be specific, accurate and understandable on its own. That is a writing and structure discipline before it is a technical one.

Specific, verifiable language.

Microsoft advises replacing vague terms with measurable facts, and notes that unanchored claims such as “next-gen” leave AI systems unsure how to classify content [3]. Google says unique, first-hand, non-commodity content will likely matter more over time than any other tip in its guide [5].

Vague	Specific (illustrative)
A world-class coastal retreat	Four-bedroom villa, sleeps eight, heated pool, six minutes from the nearest swimming beach
Unforgettable views	Ocean-facing deck with a view along the bay
Perfect for families	Pool is unfenced; children need supervision; travel cot on request

Examples are illustrative, modelled on the sample Branders page. The principle is sourced [3]; the examples are mine.

Structured data that matches the page.

- Microsoft: schema, usually JSON-LD, labels content as a product, review, FAQ or event so machines can interpret it [3].
- Google: markup must match the visible text on the page [4]. No special schema is needed for AI features, but structured data is still worth keeping for rich-result eligibility [5].
- Google's VacationRental rich results are limited to sites connected with a Google account manager and Hotel Center access [6].

IF IMPLEMENTING VACATIONRENTAL, GOOGLE REQUIRES [6]

- containsPlace with occupancy, an identifier, a name
- At least 8 images, including bedroom, bathroom and common area
- Latitude and longitude with at least 5 decimal places
- Amenity names from Google's English list (for example pool, fireplace, wifi)
- review.datePublished on any reviews

Third-party validation.

Feefo, a review-software vendor, ran 250 queries (five query types across 50 destinations) on ChatGPT, Gemini and Perplexity. It reports that 71% of responses drew on first-party reviews: Perplexity 100%, ChatGPT 58%, Gemini 56% [8].

Reviews appeared in 67% of commercial queries and 33% of informational ones [8].

Google adds that its AI features can reflect what is said about a brand across blogs, videos and forums, and that chasing inauthentic mentions is not helpful [5].

Caveat: this is a vendor study, so read it as indicative, not definitive. The practical conclusion is to earn genuine reviews and mark them up honestly, following Google's review guidelines [6].

Claims the evidence does not support.

Claim in circulation	What the sources say
Inconsistent brands are “mathematically penalised” by AI	No source found. Microsoft’s post does not describe this.
Schema is required to be cited in AI answers	Google: no special schema needed [5]. Treat as supportive, not decisive.
Content must be chunked into tiny pieces	Google: no such requirement [5]. Microsoft favours clear, modular sections [3]. Platforms differ.
llms.txt files help visibility	Google Search ignores them [5].
GEO is a separate discipline	Google: it is still SEO [5]. Microsoft: no secret strategy guarantees selection [3].

Good GEO is evidence-led, platform-aware and measured. Guidance differs between platforms and keeps changing.

What to do with this.

- Replace vague superlatives with specific, checkable facts [3].
- Keep structured data identical to what visitors see, and follow Google's documentation for the types used [4][6].
- Earn real guest reviews and present them honestly [5][8].
- Create unique, first-hand content that others cannot copy [5].
- Measure: Google's Search Console has a Generative AI performance report [5]; track other platforms by repeated query testing.

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